

S04-05 - Toward Open Vale

Player text

The Custodian gathers what she needs with the brisk energy of someone much younger than she looks. "The Open Vale is where the ward was first forged," she says. "It is where it must be renewed." She looks at each of you in turn. "I cannot do this alone, and what comes for us when the magic rises will not be gentle. But I think you already knew the job was bigger than a crate." When you are ready, the treehouse unfolds one last time, and the road to the Open Vale opens before you.

Public objective

Commit to the ritual and set out for the Open Vale.

Raw source

- Id: S04-05
- Type: scene
- Sectionid: ACT-FOUR
- Sectiontitle: Act Four: The Hanging Office
- Title: Toward Open Vale
- Shorttitle: Toward Open Vale
- Order: 505
- Playersafe: True
- Completioneligible: True
- Image: assets/scenes/S04-05-toward-open-vale.png
- Alt: Toward Open Vale scene art for The Hanging Office.
- Caption: The final approach turns understanding into preparation.
- Mood: The Hanging Office
- Gmgoal: Convert the reveal into commitment, offer real preparation, and bridge to Act 5.
- Publicobjective: Commit to the ritual and set out for the Open Vale.
- Readaloud: The Custodian gathers what she needs with the brisk energy of someone much younger than she looks. "The Open Vale is where the ward was first forged," she says. "It is where it must be renewed." She looks at each of you in turn. "I cannot do this alone, and what comes for us when the magic rises will not be gentle. But I think you already knew the job was bigger than a crate." When you are ready, the treehouse unfolds one last time, and the road to the Open Vale opens before you.
- Gmnotes: This is the bridge scene. The important output is state, not more lore. A reluctant yes still counts if the party chooses the hard road with eyes open.
- Gmscript: Say: "Before we go: you can rest, prepare, ask her what to expect, or spend any favor you earned. It all matters when the ritual starts."
- Gmreadaloud: "The Open Vale is where the ward was first forged." "I cannot do this alone." The treehouse unfolds one last time, and the road to the Open Vale opens before you.
- Gmchecklist: Do not railroad the yes; let the stakes and trust carry it. Offer prep: rest, learn the ritual, spend festival_boon or Hush favor, plan positions. Set

- ritual_prep ready/unready. Set final custodian_trust. Set ward_stability fragile/stable for Act 5. Use MAP-LOC-open-vale-ward-lines as the forward edge.
- Gmprivate: Convergence math: high trust + deep understanding + ready prep = ward_stability stable. Otherwise fragile. If package_status=lost, commitment can exist emotionally but Act 5 cannot proceed normally until the recovery branch is confirmed.
 - Playertakeaway: You are choosing the hard road on purpose, and what you do before you walk it will keep you alive.
 - Storytakeaway: The party chooses to finish what the job started, not just because of pay but because the stakes are now real.
 - Mechanictakeaway: Preparation is the mechanic: rest, learn, spend boons, and plan; ritual_prep and ward_stability set the Act 5 countdown pressure.
 - Rollcards: s04-05-carry-the-keystone-through-the-dark-path S04-05 Carry the Keystone through the dark path Carry the Keystone through the dark path Strength Agility Strength Agility 12 Strength bears weight; Agility moves safely with it. The asset becomes a burden at the worst moment. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The asset becomes a burden at the worst moment. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result...
 - Entityids: open-valetm-ritual-site whitefire-custodian keystone-asset marlowe-fairwind ritual-countdown short-rest varian-soto sealed-keystone-crate ward-moths sunfire-lily mist-things
 - Entities: open-valetm-ritual-site Open Vale? Ritual Site location Location assets/icons/location.png assets/location-visuals/open-valetm-ritual-site/profile_scene_v02.png OH-pen vayl RICH-oo-ul site An ancient circular clearing of standing stones and ward-light, with a freshly painted company marker staked at its edge. Make the final arena feel sacred, neglected, and operational all at once. Ancient circular clearing rebranded by Goldspire; where the ward renewal happens.; introduce it with a sensory palette, who feels safe there, and what has been neglected. Pull player attention toward the choices, clues, and relationships tied to Whitefire Custodian, Keystone Asset, Legacy Security Skeleton. Ancient circular clearing rebranded by Goldspire; where the ward renewal happens. whitefire-custodian Whitefire Custodian npc NPC / Ally assets/icons/npc.png assets/npc-images/whitefire-custodian/portrait_base.png WHITE-fire kus-TOH-dee-un Old faerie-like custodian who maintains the ward protecting Hush. Truth-bearer for the Keystone reveal. Whitefire Custodian an old faerie-like ward keeper whose exhaustion glows around the edges Ancient kindness running on fumes, glowing a little brighter whenever...
 - Locationids: open-valetm-ritual-site
 - Itemids: whitefire-ward-charm
 - Statecontrols: custodian_trust Custodian Trust select low neutral high

ward_stability Ward Stability select fragile stable ritual_prep Ritual Prep select
unready ready keystone_understanding Keystone Understanding select surface deep
festival_boon Festival Boon select none charm favor market_find goodwill
package_status Package Status select held lost

- Mechanicids: strength agility vulnerable armor-slots short-rest knowledge presence
hope fear table-spotlight
- Playerquestions: Who says yes, and what does yes cost your character? What do you do
before the road opens: rest, learn, spend a favor, or plan defense?
- Relationshipprompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees
about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownershipprompt: Name one detail in Toward Open Vale that belongs to your
character's point of view.
- Fearsponds: Spend Fear to expose neglected infrastructure, stress the Custodian, or
make the Keystone hum at the wrong moment. Make neglected infrastructure answer at
the wrong moment. Stress the Custodian's trust without turning her into a device.
- Choicesconsequences: Commit and prepare The party rests, asks questions, spends
boons, or plans positions. Set ritual_prep=ready; ward_stability can become stable
if trust/understanding support it. Act 5 ritual countdown starts kinder and the
Custodian aid is stronger. ritual_prep ready; ward_stability stable possible benefit
player-visible Commit but rush The party keeps momentum but leaves questions and
resources unused. Set ritual_prep=unready; ward_stability likely fragile. Act 5
begins under harder pressure. ritual_prep unready; ward_stability fragile penalty
player-visible Spend festival_boon or Hush favor A charm, favor, market find, or
goodwill becomes real prep. Can improve ritual_prep or justify ward_stability
stable. The Act 3 festival choice pays off in the finale. festival_boon spent;
ritual_prep ready benefit player-visible Ask the Custodian what to expect She names
the ritual shape and what the rising magic will draw. Knowledge or Presence can
clarify roles; set ritual_prep=ready. Act 5 starts with better fictional
positioning. ritual_prep ready benefit player-visible
- Lootclues: Approach advantage One preparation detail each player names Whitefire
Custodian's Ward-Charm: A small hand-carved wooden ratcoon mid-scamper has been
thumb-worn smooth for luck. It is warm, and the forest feels a little kinder while
you hold it.
- Handoutids: Open Vale pull
- Sourcescenelug: S04-05-toward-open-vale
- Sourcefiles: dist/Act4_Upgrade_Packet/ACT4_SCENE_RESEARCH.md
dist/Act4_Upgrade_Packet/ACT4_MAPS_AND_LOCATIONS.md
- References: Open Vale Ward Lines #MAP-LOC-open-vale-ward-lines Act Five #ACT-FIVE
- Storyscope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie
about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it
by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the
danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. The sealed package is the
capital's ward Keystone; the city is unwarded while it is away. KEEP GUARANTEED "The
wood never needed managing. It needed leaving alone." ADD SEED "Your capital's
safety is older than your contracts. It is the very thing they teach you to fear."
ADD SEED The Keystone's magic is pre-corporate forest-ward work, the same school
companies call primitive. ADD EARNED Knowledge Hard 20 The Custodian glances at
obsolete Soulspire inspection seals on her counterweight boulder. ADD EARNED

Instinct Medium 15 Presence: earn candor. Knowledge: place the magic. Instinct: read the Custodian's fear. ACT4 Act 4: Hanging Office 160 2:05 to 2:40 2:40 Custodian, Keystone reveal, new objective, short rest Compress the reveal; bank the Short Rest into travel narration.

- Livetools: none
- Percharacterlayer: khari-nix Khari Nix The commitment A guardian can anchor the party's yes. Can be the one who says they will help. Khari, if anyone is going to say 'we will help,' it is you. Want to be the one who commits the party? marlowe-fairwind Marlowe Fairwind Ritual prep Best placed to learn the ritual shape from the Custodian. Knowledge 13 Learns the ritual structure and helps set ritual_prep=ready. Can translate arcane prep into table roles. Marlowe, she will teach you the ritual's shape if you ask. Want to learn it and prep the party? garrick-reed Garrick Reed Defense plan Naturally plans who guards whom when danger arrives. Can establish Act 5 positioning and watches. Garrick, you can plan how to defend her mid-ritual. Want to set the watch order now? varian-soto Varian Soto Scout the draw Can sense what the rising magic might attract from the deep preserve. Instinct 13 Foreshadows Act 5 danger and helps prepare routes. Can scout the approach in fiction before the party moves. Varian, you can read what the deep preserve will send when the magic rises. Want to scout ahead in your mind? barnacle Barnacle Cash in favors Knows how to turn festival_boon or Hush goodwill into actual prep...
- Takeawayhelp: Player takeaway You are choosing the hard road on purpose. "You have signed on for something real. Use this moment: rest, ready up, ask questions." "Rest, gear up, ask the Custodian what is coming, or spend a favor you earned in Hush. Then we ride." If players hesitate, name the stakes and give them agency. A city falls if nobody renews the ward. short-rest knowledge presence hope Story takeaway The party chooses to finish what the job started. "This is the yes. Not for coin, because you have seen enough to care how this ends." "She does not force you. She names the stakes, and your characters decide whether they can walk away." Let reluctant characters be reluctant. Commitment is stronger when it is not automatic. short-rest knowledge presence hope Mechanic takeaway Preparation is the mechanic. "Before we go: rest, prepare, ask what to expect, or spend any favor you earned. It all matters when the ritual starts." "Ready prep eases Act 5. Rushing makes ward_stability fragile and the countdown harsher." Set ward_stability from convergence: trust, understanding, prep, and boons. short-rest knowledge presence hope
- Playerbeats: S04-05-yes The yes Toward Open Vale assets/scenes/S04-05-toward-open-vale.png Toward Open Vale scene art for The Hanging Office. The Custodian asks for help, and the table chooses whether to carry the danger forward. The Custodian asks for help, and the table chooses whether to carry the danger forward. The Custodian asks for help, and the table chooses whether to carry the danger forward. image-title-caption S04-05-prep Preparation Preparation assets/scenes/S04-05-toward-open-vale.png Toward Open Vale scene art for The Hanging Office. Rest, ask what is coming, learn the ritual shape, spend a favor, or plan who protects whom. Rest, ask what is coming, learn the ritual shape, spend a favor, or plan who protects whom. Rest, ask what is coming, learn the ritual shape, spend a favor, or plan who protects whom. text-first S04-05-road Road opens The road opens assets/scenes/S04-05-toward-open-vale.png Toward Open Vale scene art for The Hanging Office. The treehouse unfolds one last time, and the road to the Open Vale opens

before you. The treehouse unfolds one last time, and the road to the Open Vale opens before you. The treehouse unfolds one last time, and the road to the Open Vale...

- Gmbeats: S04-05-yes The yes Toward Open Vale Say: "This is the yes. Not for coin, because you have seen enough to care how this ends.". The Custodian asks for help, and the table chooses whether to carry the danger forward. The delivery becomes duty. Commitment changes state, not just tone. Players know commitment is a choice. Player takeaway Players know commitment is a choice. "This is the yes. Not for coin, because you have seen enough to care how this ends." "The playable fact is: The Custodian asks for help, and the table chooses whether to carry the danger forward." Concrete actions for this beat: look closely, ask the Custodian a direct question, commit to a choice, or take one prep action. presence Story takeaway The delivery becomes duty. "This is the yes. Not for coin, because you have seen enough to care how this ends." "The story fact in play is: The delivery becomes duty." This beat changes Act 4 through this exact pressure: The delivery becomes duty. presence Mechanic takeaway Commitment changes state, not just tone. "This is the yes. Not for coin, because you have seen enough to care how this ends." "The active procedure is: Commitment changes state, not just tone." Run...
- Beatautoplayeligible: True
- Beatautoplaydefault: False
- Beatautoplayintervalms: 8500
- Playersafeprojection: S04-05 scene Toward Open Vale assets/scenes/S04-05-toward-open-vale.png Toward Open Vale scene art for The Hanging Office. The final approach turns understanding into preparation. The Hanging Office Commit to the ritual and set out for the Open Vale. The Custodian gathers what she needs with the brisk energy of someone much younger than she looks. "The Open Vale is where the ward was first forged," she says. "It is where it must be renewed." She looks at each of you in turn. "I cannot do this alone, and what comes for us when the magic rises will not be gentle. But I think you already knew the job was bigger than a crate." When you are ready, the treehouse unfolds one last time, and the road to the Open Vale opens before you. S04-05-yes The yes Toward Open Vale assets/scenes/S04-05-toward-open-vale.png Toward Open Vale scene art for The Hanging Office. The Custodian asks for help, and the table chooses whether to carry the danger forward. The Custodian asks for help, and the table chooses whether to carry the danger forward. The Custodian asks for help, and the table chooses whether to carry the danger forward. image-title-caption S04-05-prep Preparation Preparation...
- Slidenumber: 60
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